

The Best Places to Eat Zarzuela

Restaurante Set Portes *expensive*

Everyone from Che Guevara to Errol Flynn, and from the King of Spain to Yoko Ono, has dined at Set Portes, and commemorative plaques even mark their favored seats. Founded in 1836, the restaurant famously has seven entrances, and shares the building where Picasso and his parents first lived when they came to Barcelona in 1895. After the Spanish Civil War, Set Portes emerged as the most elegant restaurant in Barcelona, and it has tenaciously clung to its crown by serving only brilliant preparations of the best ingredients. The restaurant's version of zarzuela always features a generous half (the one with the large claw) of an Atlantic lobster, as well as cuts of fish that other restaurants would reserve for grilling. The wine list is optimally paired with the menu and is particularly robust, with Priorat reds and Penedés whites from Catalonia.

Passeig Isabel II 14, Barcelona; open 1 PM–1 AM daily; www.7portes.com

Also in Barcelona

As the son of a fisherman, the proprietor of the Barcelona tavern **Can Majó** (www.canmajo.es; *moderate*) knows how to make a brilliant zarzuela. Book ahead for an outdoor table overlooking the harbor. **Can Culleretes** (www.culleretes.com; *inexpensive*) is a marvelously old-fashioned restaurant (founded in 1786) that often caters to large groups, and serves a good zarzuela among its many Catalan specialties.

Also in Catalonia

Few zarzuelas are so loaded with amazing crustaceans as the version served at **Restaurant Sa Gambina** (www.restaurantsagambina.com; *moderate*) in Cadaqués. Their "Gala-Dalí zarzuela" was named for painter Salvador Dalí and his wife Gaia, who ordered it frequently when living in Cadaqués. Considered by many to be perhaps Spain's greatest seafood restaurant, **Joan Gatell Restaurant** (www.joangatell.com; *expensive*) in Cambrils makes a transporting zarzuela as well as *suquet*, a humbler but similar soup without the crustaceans.

Around the World

Any seafood stew with crustaceans, clams, and mussels could technically be called a zarzuela, but in the resorts of coastal Colombia and Venezuela, cooks prepare a *mariscada* that traces its roots to the Spanish zarzuela. An excellent version is available daily at **Restaurante de Albahaca** (+58 295 263 7552; *inexpensive*) on Venezuela's Isla de Margarita. A *mariscada* made with dark beer and seasoned with cilantro is the house special of **Juan del Mar Restaurant** (+57 5 664 5862; *moderate*) in Cartagena, Colombia.

